

DESIGNERS' HEYDAY

The late 19th century marked the beginning of a creative outpouring in the jewellery world that reached its height in the 1930s. One factor was the abundant supply of large gems on the market from newly opened mines in South Africa. These larger gemstones required lighter settings, challenging jewellers to develop new styles. Britain's Queen Alexandra was another catalyst. Wearing extravagant jewels by day, she personified the *belle époque*, an age of flamboyant, frivolous fashions, and jewels – it was the perfect time to be a jewellery designer.

Among the names to make their mark in the 1930s were the French designers René Lalique, Cartier, Mauboussin, and Boivin, becoming some of the most sought-after design houses in the jewellery world. René Boivin founded his Paris workshop in 1890, but it was not until the 1930s, under the control of Boivin's wife Jeanne, that the house became known for its bold, original pieces. Around this time, Hollywood also bought fine jewellery to the public's attention. Marlene Dietrich commissioned a pair of emerald and diamond bracelets from Mauboussin, one of which she wore in the 1936 film *Desire*; her patronage helped seal the jeweller's fortunes.

It was a toss-up whether I'd go in for diamonds or sing in the choir. The choir lost

Mae **West**
Hollywood actress

An illustration by Georges Lepape for Vogue, 1933 This illustration showcases pieces by some of the leading jewellery houses of the 1930s – Cartier, Mauboussin, and René Boivin. They were all founded in the 19th century, but rose to fame in the 1930s with the help of Hollywood.

